How Soccer Functions as a Religion in Brazil

Brianna R. Imm

University of Missouri

Author Note

Brianna R. Imm https://orcid.org/0009-0000-0092-632X

Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Brianna R. Imm. Email: briannarimm@gmail.com

Abstract

Although scholars frequently characterize sports as religions, this description is usually treated as rhetorical rather than analytical. This article addresses the theoretical and empirical problem of how soccer functions precisely as a religion by examining the case of Brazil, where the game is widely asserted to be a national religion yet has rarely been analyzed through the theoretical vocabulary of religious studies. Adopting a consistent functional definition of religion built on the frameworks of Émile Durkheim and Clifford Geertz, the study demonstrates that soccer performs core religious functions on a national scale. Specifically, the game establishes sacred spaces and times, generates collective effervescence and moral communities through ritual assembly, and deploys a symbol system that formulates and legitimates a powerful conception of the nation. Furthermore, common objections regarding superstition, relics, and player deification are reinterpreted as standard religious phenomena under a functional lens. The findings indicate that soccer operates as a unifying civil religion that coexists harmoniously with Brazil's plural institutional faiths. The implications suggest that functional frameworks offer robust tools for analyzing postcolonial cultural phenomena and highlight the value of looking beyond North America and Europe in the study of sport as religion.

Keywords: soccer, religion, Brazil, functional definition, collective effervescence, civil religion

How Soccer Functions as a Religion in Brazil

Soccer is a global phenomenon, and outside the United States it is woven into everyday life. It has heroes, rituals, emblems, and sacred places, and players, journalists, and fans regularly call it a religion. That description is usually rhetorical. This article treats it as an analytical claim and asks what it means, precisely, for soccer to *function* as a religion.

Brazil provides a compelling example of how soccer functions as a religion for a country's population. Scholarship on sport as religion is substantial, but it concentrates on the United States and, to a lesser extent, Europe (Bain-Selbo, 2009; Bromberger, 1995; Novak, 1976; Prebish, 1993; Price, 2001). Conversely, Brazil, where soccer is commonly called the national religion, has several studies on the social science of the game, but that scholarship has rarely used the theoretical vocabulary of religious studies (DaMatta, 1982; Kittleson, 2014; Leite Lopes, 2000; Lever, 1983). Brazil is thus both the case the comparative literature most conspicuously omits and the case in which the religious description is often asserted.

Soccer performs, in Brazil, the functions that Durkheim and Geertz identify as religious, and that it does so intensively and at national scale. The argument proceeds in four steps. The Theoretical Framework section sets out the definitional framework and explains why a functional definition, applied consistently, is required. The Background section supplies the background: the scholarship on sport as religion, the history of institutional religion in Brazil, and the making of Brazilian soccer. The Discussion section applies the framework and identifies five religious functions that soccer performs in Brazil, and then it considers seven alternative interpretations of that evidence. The Conclusion follows.

Theoretical Framework: Defining Religion

Any claim that something "is" or "functions as" a religion depends on a definition, and the definition determines the relevant evidence. The difficulty of supplying one is well documented. As Kathryn Lofton observes, "Within departments of religious studies, defining religion has become almost absurdly impossible, resulting in undergraduate program descriptions and doctoral mission statements that look more like the result of a game of Exquisite Corpse than reasoned roundtable deduction" (Lofton, 2011, p. 3). That difficulty does not excuse imprecision. In particular, it does not permit an analysis to draw on two incompatible kinds of definition at once.

Substantive and Functional Definitions

Scholars distinguish *substantive* from *functional* definitions of religion (Berger, 1967, pp. 175–178; Berger, 1974). A substantive definition identifies religion by its content, ordinarily a relationship with supernatural or superhuman beings. Melford Spiro's formulation is the standard example: religion is "an institution consisting of culturally patterned interaction with culturally postulated superhuman beings" (Spiro, 1966, p. 96). A functional definition identifies religion by what it does, such as integrating a group, sacralizing its values, or supplying an ordered picture of the world, and it is indifferent to whether gods are involved. Thomas Luckmann's account of religion as the symbolic universe through which human beings transcend their biological nature is a far-reaching example (Luckmann, 1967).

The two approaches pose different questions and therefore call for different evidence. Under a substantive definition, the question about soccer is whether fans actually believe in occult forces, and the answer turns on what they report and how charitably those reports are read. Under a functional definition, that question is immaterial. The relevant questions are whether soccer sets

things apart as sacred, assembles people into a moral community, and supplies symbols that make a picture of the world feel real. The substantive and functionalist approaches are independent of each other: each test can be applied coherently, but a conclusion reached under one cannot rest on evidence that is relevant only under the other. This article adopts a functional definition and applies it throughout.

Durkheim and Geertz

Émile Durkheim's *Elementary Forms* is the foundational functionalist text, and it is functionalist by design. Durkheim expressly rejects definitions built on the supernatural or on divinity, on the grounds that the idea of the supernatural presupposes a modern conception of natural order and that traditions such as Buddhism are religious without centering a god (Durkheim, 1915, Book 1, Chapter 1). He substitutes the division of the world into sacred and profane:

> All known religious beliefs, whether simple or complex, present one common characteristic: they presuppose a classification of all the things, real and ideal, of which men think, into two classes or opposed groups, generally designated by two distinct terms which are translated well enough by the words profane and sacred. … But by sacred things one must not understand simply those personal beings which are called gods or spirits; a rock, a tree, a spring, a pebble, a piece of wood, a house, in a word, anything can be sacred. (Durkheim, 1915, p. 37)

His formal definition follows: "A religion is a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden—beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them" (Durkheim, 1915, p. 47). The operative elements are the set-apartness of the sacred and the moral community it consti-

tutes, not any object of belief. For Durkheim, the sacred is ultimately society itself, represented to its members in symbolic form. Accordingly, religion is a social institution, and its study is a branch of sociology.

Clifford Geertz supplies the second element. His definition treats religion as a cultural system of meaning:

> [A] religion is: (1) a system of symbols which acts to (2) establish powerful, pervasive, and long-lasting moods and motivations in men by (3) formulating conceptions of a general order of existence and (4) clothing these conceptions with such an aura of factuality that (5) the moods and motivations seem uniquely realistic. (Geertz, 1973, p. 90)

Geertz's definition is likewise functional. Each of its five clauses describes what symbols *do*, and none refers to supernatural beings. The two definitions are complementary rather than redundant. Durkheim identifies the social mechanism: sacralization and collective ritual produce a moral community. Geertz identifies the semantic content: a particular symbol system makes a particular conception of the world compelling. Applied to soccer, Durkheim directs the inquiry to what the game does for the group, and Geertz directs it to what conception of the world its symbols make real.

Scope of the Claim

The thesis is therefore narrower than the colloquial claim that "soccer is a religion." It does not assert that soccer is equivalent to Catholicism, and it makes no claim about any individual's metaphysical commitments. It asserts that soccer in Brazil performs a specific cluster of functions identified as religious by Durkheim and Geertz: it sets apart sacred times, places, persons, and objects; it gathers Brazilians into ritual assemblies that generate collective emotion and moral com-

munity; and its symbols formulate a compelling conception of the nation. Whether a given fan believes that a lucky shirt has occult efficacy is not an element of that claim. For precision, this article uses "institutional religions" to denote the traditions conventionally classified as religions, such as Catholicism and Pentecostalism.

Background

Sport as Religion in the Scholarly Literature

The scholarship on sport as religion is now several decades deep, and it is predominantly functional in orientation. Michael Novak argued that American sports are religious in their organization, their ritual calendar, and the devotion they command (Novak, 1976). Charles Prebish extended the claim, contending that sport functions as religion for many Americans, while Shirl Hoffman's collection gathered essays on both sides of the question (Hoffman, 1992; Prebish, 1993). Joseph Price read the American sporting calendar as a liturgical year, and Eric Bain-Selbo combined survey data with Durkheimian theory to show that college football rituals in the American South generate the cohesion and moral orientation associated with religion (Bain-Selbo, 2009; Price, 2001).

This literature does not cast sport and institutional religion as rivals. As Jeffrey Scholes and Raphael Sassower explain, "Religion and sports are not in competition with each other for who gets the right to teach such values; each can accomplish this function in its own way and even draw on each other, if needed, as Paul did 2,000 years ago" (Scholes & Sassower, 2014, p. 5). That point is significant for Brazil, where, as the Discussion shows, soccer and institutional religion interpenetrate.

Two further bodies of work supply the mechanism and the empirical grounding. First, Randall Collins's theory of interaction ritual chains, which builds directly on Durkheim, specifies the conditions under which ritual produces solidarity. Bodily co-presence, a shared focus of attention,

and a shared mood combine to generate collective effervescence, emotional energy, and symbols charged with group membership; the sporting event is among his paradigm cases (Collins, 2004). Second, the ethnography and social psychology of fandom document those effects in practice. Christian Bromberger's fieldwork among supporters in Marseille, Naples, and Turin treats the match as a ritual that dramatizes collective identity, and Richard Giulianotti situates such identities within the global commercialization of the game (Bromberger, 1995; Giulianotti, 1999). Most directly, Martha Newson and colleagues found, in a study of 465 Brazilian supporters, that "identity fusion," a visceral merging of personal and group identity, predicted willingness to fight for one's club when combined with perceived outgroup threat (Newson et al., 2018). That finding measures, among Brazilian fans, the dissolution of self into group that Durkheim theorized.

Institutional Religion in Brazil

Brazil's religious history explains why a shared, cross-confessional ritual idiom could take hold. Portuguese colonization was a Catholic project; according to Thomas Bruneau, the conversion of Indigenous peoples was conceived as an extension of the Iberian Reconquista (Bruneau, 1982, p. 11). Under the royal patronage system (*padroado*), however, the colonial church answered to the Crown more than to Rome. The Crown declared the colony Catholic, but for most inhabitants Catholicism functioned as an identity rather than a disciplined belief system (Bruneau, 1982, p. 15). Thin clerical presence and attenuated ties to the Vatican produced a popular Catholicism that absorbed Indigenous practices and the religious practices of enslaved Africans (Bastide, 1978; Bruneau, 1982, pp. 15–16). Bruneau summarizes the result:

> Those who have studied religion, culture, and small communities in Brazil have consistently remarked on the tremendous variety of religious beliefs and practices and the ease with

> which the people adopt new religious patterns … The church is frequently regarded as a social necessity—a comfortable presence rather than a compelling force. (Bruneau, 1982, p. 21)

The relationship between church and state shifted in the twentieth century. The early Republic formally separated church and state. From the 1910s through the 1930s, however, the hierarchy, led by Cardinal Sebastião Leme, pursued a "neo-Christendom" strategy of restoring Catholic influence through cooperation with the state and a more orthodox, clergy-centered practice (Della Cava, 1976; Mainwaring, 1986). Bruneau describes a church that "cooperated intimately with the Brazilian state" and grew more orthodox under Leme's direction, even as popular practice remained varied and individual (Bruneau, 1982, pp. 19–20, 22, 25–26).

Since Bruneau wrote, the religious field has become markedly more plural. Pentecostal and neo-Pentecostal churches have grown rapidly (Chesnut, 1997). Brazil's 2022 census found that 56.7 percent of the population aged ten and over identified as Catholic, down from 65.1 percent in 2010, while evangelicals rose to 26.9 percent and the religiously unaffiliated to 9.3 percent (Instituto Brasileiro de Geografia e Estatística, 2025). Brazil remains a majority-Catholic country, but no institutional religion now commands the near-universal identification that colonial Catholicism once did. That plurality matters for a specific reason: it removed the one institution that had been able to stage a national public ritual. The Republic's separation of church and state did not end Catholic privileges, and through the late 1950s the hierarchy worked to impede the growth of its religious competitors (Mariano, 2011, pp. 246–247). Religious pluralism consolidated only in the last quarter of the twentieth century, with redemocratization and the growth of Pentecostalism, which broke the monopolistic logic that had governed the religious field (Mariano, 2011, pp. 247–248). Even at its

height, as Bruneau's account shows, Catholic hegemony rested more on inherited identity than on disciplined practice. Antônio Flávio Pierucci describes what follows when such identities lose their hold: in post-traditional societies, inherited affiliations decline, become optional and revisable, and give way to experimental ties of low consistency (Pierucci, 2004, p. 19). A confession that its members choose cannot serve as the ritual of a whole nation, because its rites now mark one community off from the others. When the Pentecostal bloc in the 1986 Constituent Assembly listed Catholics and practitioners of Afro-Brazilian religions among its adversaries, it showed how far confessional identity had come to divide rather than unite (Mariano, 2011, p. 251).

Durkheim anticipated this situation. Reflecting on the moral uncertainty of his own time, he wrote that "the old gods are growing old or already dead, and others are not yet born," and predicted that societies would again know hours of creative effervescence and would commemorate them in regular celebrations (Durkheim, 1915, p. 427). Soccer was positioned to supply those celebrations in Brazil for three reasons. First, it belongs to no confession, so a Catholic, an evangelical, a practitioner of Candomblé, and an unbeliever can join its rites without renouncing their own. Second, it had become a mass, cross-class practice before religious pluralization accelerated; from the 1950s the Maracanã set the pattern for Brazilian stadiums, commonly regarded as democratic, affordable to all, and, at least in principle, open across classes (Hollanda & Medeiros, 2014, p. 338). Third, it already possessed what a national ritual requires: a calendar, a national team that stands for the whole, and a symbol system tied to the nation, as the next subsection shows. The vacuum, in short, was not one of belief but one of shared public ritual, and soccer filled it.

The Making of Brazilian Soccer

Soccer's rise in Brazil coincided with the Catholic restoration. Mauricio Murad dates the game's arrival to 1894, when Charles Miller returned to São Paulo from schooling in England, while

noting that it may already have been played in Rio de Janeiro and in Itu, in São Paulo state (Murad, 2014, p. 100). In its first decades soccer was an Anglophile pastime of urban elites, and its leading clubs excluded Black and working-class players (Bocketti, 2016; Pereira, 2000).

Those barriers were contested and then broken in the 1920s and early 1930s. In 1923, Vasco da Gama won the Rio championship with a team that included Black and working-class players; when elite clubs reorganized the league in 1924 to exclude such players, Vasco refused to drop them. The adoption of professionalism in 1933 opened the game further (Leite Lopes, 2000; Pereira, 2000). Brazil had by then competed in the first World Cup, held in Uruguay in 1930 (Murad, 2014, p. 100). The journalist Mário Filho and the sociologist Gilberto Freyre converted this history into a national narrative, in which a distinctively "mulatto" football demonstrated that a mixed-race nation could achieve greatness by being itself (Leite Lopes, 2000; Mostaro et al., 2015; Mário Filho, 1947). Later scholarship has shown how far that narrative simplified a history of exclusion, and how the "Brazilian style" was itself constructed (Abrahão et al., 2011; Bocketti, 2016; Kittleson, 2014; Souza, 2018). For functional analysis, however, the construction is the point. In Geertz's terms, a symbol system was being assembled that would formulate a conception of national order and clothe it with an aura of factuality.

The religious and sporting trajectories thus ran in parallel. While the Catholic hierarchy pursued orthodoxy and alliance with the state, soccer became a mass, cross-class, multiracial practice. Murad reports that survey research by the State University of Rio de Janeiro (UERJ) and Universo identifies soccer as the country's largest social-cultural activity (Murad, 2014, pp. 99–103). Soccer and Catholicism did not compete as theologies. They did, however, become the two most widely shared idioms of Brazilian collective life, and in a society now divided among Catholics, evangelicals, Afro-Brazilian traditions, and the unaffiliated, soccer is the more universally shared of the two.

Brazil is a soccer nation that also happens to be primarily, and decreasingly, Catholic.

Discussion

This article asked whether soccer in Brazil performs the functions that Durkheim and Geertz identify as religious. Measured against the framework set out in the Theoretical Framework section, the evidence indicates that it performs five such functions. Each corresponds to an element of the Durkheimian or Geertzian definition. The first part of this section interprets the evidence for each function, and the second considers alternative interpretations of that evidence and the limits they place on the argument.

The Religious Functions of Soccer in Brazil

Sacred Space and Time

Durkheim's sacred is, first, what is set apart. Brazilian soccer has set-apart places, and the foremost is Rio de Janeiro's Maracanã stadium. Christopher Gaffney's comparative study of stadiums in Rio and Buenos Aires treats such grounds as "temples" within a cultural landscape, sites at which civic identity is ritually produced and remembered (Gaffney, 2008; Moraes et al., 2018, p. 34). Soccer also has a sacred calendar. The World Cup, held every four years, suspends ordinary time (Gastaldo, 2013), and its triumphs and catastrophes, from the 1950 defeat to Uruguay at the Maracanã to the victories of 1958, 1962, 1970, 1994, and 2002, operate as a national sacred history that is commemorated and retold.

Collective Effervescence and Moral Community

The ritual assembly is central to Durkheim's account, because it is in the crowd that individuals experience themselves as carried by a force larger than themselves. The Brazilian match day is such an assembly. Janet Lever's fieldwork in Rio showed that club allegiances organize social life and that the national team, in turn, unites rival club loyalties into a single national commu-

nity (Gastaldo, 2010; Lever, 1983; Vargas-Salfate et al., 2020). Collins's interaction ritual theory explains why the mechanism works: the stadium supplies co-presence, the ball a single focus of attention, and the drama of the match a shared and rising mood (Collins, 2004; Xygalatas et al., 2025). Furthermore, the identity fusion that Newson and colleagues measured among Brazilian fans is the merging of self and group that Durkheim theorized, together with the moral intensity, including at times violent loyalty, that such merging sustains (Newson et al., 2018).

A Symbol System of the Nation

Geertz directs attention to what religious symbols say, and in Brazil soccer's symbols formulate a conception of the nation. Roberto DaMatta argued that football dramatizes Brazilian society: it stages a world in which impersonal rules apply equally and in which the poor and Black can prevail by skill, a world that inverts, and thereby comments on, the hierarchies of everyday life (DaMatta, 1982; DaMatta, 1991). The historian Hilário Franco Júnior likewise reads football as a lens through which Brazilians interpret their own history (Franco Júnior, 2007). Murad states the point from within Brazilian scholarship:

> Thus, soccer in Brazil (as in other countries) is more than a sport; it is an expressive symbology of our historical foundations as a society, of our way of being and acting, of our identities, of our dilemmas and, perhaps, a possible means to confront and denounce our social issues (I said: possible!). (Murad, 2014, p. 103)

Murad's description tracks Geertz's definition closely. Soccer's symbols, among them the yellow shirt, the *jogo bonito*, and the improvising genius, establish moods and motivations by formulating a conception of national order, and the national team's victories clothe that conception with an aura of factuality.

The State and Civil Religion

Religion's integrative function makes it useful to states, and Brazilian governments have exploited soccer's. According to Bar-On, "Janet Lever highlighted how the Brazilian military government of the 1960s used the national game of soccer (or is it the national religion?) in order to instill in its inhabitants a notion of the nations vast geographical terrain" (Bar-On, 2014, pp. 31–32; Lever, 1983). The military regime's identification with the 1970 World Cup victory is the best-known instance (Kittleson, 2014). Robert Bellah's concept of civil religion, a set of sacred symbols and rituals through which a polity sacralizes itself independently of any church, supplies the relevant category (Bellah, 1967). In the United States, Bellah located civil religion in presidential rhetoric, national holidays, and memorials. In Brazil, soccer performs much of that work.

Coexistence with Institutional Religion

Soccer's religious function does not displace institutional religion; it provides a stage for it. Carmen Rial has documented how Brazilian players, many of them neo-Pentecostal, use the game's global visibility to display their faith through prayer circles on the pitch and religious slogans on their shirts. She describes the result as "banal religiosity" (Rial, 2012, pp. 133–136).

That coexistence was achieved against a theological tradition that rejected the game. Classical Pentecostal churches forbade their members to enjoy the pleasures of this life, sport and gambling among them, and believers called the soccer ball the "devil's egg" (Rial, 2012, p. 138). Ricardo Mariano characterizes those early churches by a radical sectarianism and an asceticism of world rejection (Mariano, 2004, p. 123). The neo-Pentecostal churches that grew from the 1970s broke with much of that countercultural asceticism, and their members were free to dress in fashion, go to beaches and cinemas, practice sports, and root for soccer teams (Mariano, 2004, p. 124). The

theology of prosperity supplied the justification: believers had the right to enjoy their happiness on Earth and could express themselves through consumer goods, music, and sport (Rial, 2012, p. 138).

Evangelicals reconcile intense church participation with intense fandom in two further ways. First, they redefine the game as a field of mission. The ball once called the devil's egg came to be valued as a privileged instrument for spreading the evangelical message, and the Atletas de Cristo movement set out to resignify sporting practice within a Christian vision (Nunes, 2006, pp. 7–8; Petrognani, 2015, p. 187). Second, the prohibitions that remain fall on conduct rather than on the game: across Pentecostal currents, the ban on alcohol, tobacco, and drugs persists (Mariano, 2004, p. 124).

The friction has not disappeared. During the 2026 World Cup, an Assembleia de Deus pastor in Recife warned of an "idolatry of football," observing that some people showed more enthusiasm for football than for faith in God (Portal de Prefeitura, 2026). The complaint supports the functional reading rather than undermining it. The pastor did not object that soccer teaches a false theology; he objected that it occupies the central place in people's hearts and attention that faith should hold, which is to say that it competes with the church on the terrain of function. The dominant evangelical response, however, has been accommodation rather than refusal, and that accommodation is the pattern that Scholes and Sassower's non-competition thesis predicts. Soccer and institutional religion draw on each other, and in Brazil's plural religious field soccer supplies a ritual space that Catholics, evangelicals, practitioners of Afro-Brazilian religions, and the unaffiliated hold in common.

Alternative Interpretations

Seven alternative interpretations of this evidence warrant consideration, each framed as an objection to the functional reading. The first three contend that the evidence of soccer's religiosity is substantive rather than functional. The next three challenge the framework and the comparative

claim. The last asks whether the commercialization of the game has undone the moral community on which the argument depends.

Superstition Demonstrates Supernatural Belief

The strongest form of the first objection runs as follows. Athletes' rituals are superstitions; superstitions are beliefs about occult causation; therefore any religiosity in sport rests on supernatural belief, and the claim is substantive after all. Scholes and Sassower's examples appear to support the premise: Michael Jordan wore his college shorts beneath his Chicago Bulls uniform, and a hockey player refused to call his mother on game days to avoid injury. The authors adopt the label "superstition" only reluctantly, because of its negative connotations (Scholes & Sassower, 2014, p. 30).

The objection fails because it misidentifies what the practices do. Bronisław Malinowski observed that Trobriand Islanders practiced little magic when fishing in the calm, predictable lagoon but surrounded dangerous open-sea fishing with elaborate ritual; magic, he concluded, appears where technical control ends and outcomes matter (Malinowski, 1948). George Gmelch found the same distribution in professional baseball. Ritual, taboo, and fetish cluster around hitting and pitching, where outcomes are highly uncertain, and are nearly absent from fielding, where success rates are high (Gmelch, 1971). Contemporary social psychology confirms the pattern. Michaéla Schippers and Paul Van Lange found that elite athletes' commitment to superstitious rituals rose with the uncertainty and importance of a match, that psychological tension mediated the effect, and that such rituals therefore serve to regulate tension (Schippers & Van Lange, 2006).

The correct analogy is not a believer petitioning a deity but a litigant who wears the same suit to every hearing. Neither holds a theory of occult causation; both are acting where the outcome lies beyond their control, and both draw composure from a fixed practice. Superstition in sport is

thus evidence of ritual performing its characteristic function, not evidence of supernatural belief and not evidence of irrationality. The claim that religions are "inherently irrational" is both substantive and unnecessary, and the functional account dispenses with it.

Relics and Deified Players Demonstrate Worship

The second objection holds that the veneration of objects and persons, such as treasured bats and jerseys and the near-deification of Pelé, shows worship of a supernatural kind. Scholes and Sassower describe bats, sticks, hats, and uniforms that function as sporting "relics" (Scholes & Sassower, 2014, p. 64). The term invites the substantive question whether fans believe that a Pelé shirt retains some residue of power.

Durkheim supplies the better vocabulary. His paradigmatic sacred object is the totem, an emblem that represents the clan to itself, so that reverence directed toward the emblem is reverence for the group. He makes the modern parallel explicit with the soldier who dies for his flag (Durkheim, 1915, Book 2, Chapter 7). The club crest and the national team's yellow shirt are totems in exactly this sense. A match-worn jersey is set apart, displayed, and protected because contact has made it an emblem of the collective, and Durkheim's observation that sacredness spreads by contact explains why objects associated with great players acquire special value (Durkheim, 1915, Book 3, Chapter 1).

> The same analysis governs persons. Tamir Bar-On reports how Pelé was regarded in Brazil:
>
> In Brazil, Pelé was seen as a safo, a player with divine inspiration who was quick and clever and could do 'forbidden things' on the pitch. The Brazilian striker Romario, the winner of the Golden Ball award and World Cup title in 1994, did not always have kind words for Pelé but recognized his transcendental significance: 'I was never one for idols. That said, I'm a

> good Brazilian and so it's only inevitable I look up to Pelé. He's like a God to us well, he is to me anyway.' (Bar-On, 2014, pp. 84–85)

Romário's "like a God" is a simile, not a theological proposition, and the functional claim does not require it to be more. Pelé is sacred in Durkheim's sense because he condenses a collective representation: the nation's image of its own creativity, joy, and excellence (Lise et al., 2017). Romário's own reasoning confirms the point, because he reveres Pelé *because* he is "a good Brazilian."

Sports Beliefs Are Falsifiable

The third objection identifies a genuine difference between sport and institutional religion. As Scholes and Sassower put it, "[U]nlike religious belief, the legitimacy of a 'sports belief' is more heavily tied to observed and measurable performance" (Scholes & Sassower, 2014, p. 29). A lucky shirt can be shown, over a season, not to work, whereas theological propositions are rarely exposed to such a test. On this view, a sporting ritual that survives disconfirmation is merely an error, not a religion.

The objection carries weight only under a substantive definition. Under a functional definition, the persistence of ritual despite disconfirming evidence is precisely what the account predicts, because the ritual's value lies in what it does for the practitioner, not in its predictive accuracy. Asking whether a pre-game ritual has been falsified misreads it in the same way that asking whether a wedding ceremony is accurate misreads a wedding. Stuart Vyse's review of the psychology of superstition, and Jane Risen's account of how people "acquiesce" to intuitions they know to be false, both describe practices sustained by their felt benefits despite explicit disbelief (Risen, 2016; Vyse, 2014).

Whether superstition improves performance is a separate and contested question. An influential experiment reported performance benefits from activating superstitions, but a replication study did not reproduce the effect (Calin-Jageman & Caldwell, 2014; Damisch et al., 2010). The functional claim does not depend on that effect. It depends only on the better-supported finding that ritual commitment tracks uncertainty and tension. How sporting rituals adapt when their apparent efficacy is disconfirmed remains an open empirical question.

The Functional Definition Is Overbroad

The fourth objection is that a functional definition proves too much. If religion is whatever performs religious functions, then nationalism, political ideologies, and fandoms all qualify, and the term loses analytical force. Berger pressed this objection forcefully, and Kevin Schilbrack has more recently asked what, on a given definition, would *not* count as religion (Berger, 1974; Schilbrack, 2013).

The objection limits the scope of the thesis without defeating it, for two reasons. First, the thesis is not that every activity with devotees is a religion. It is that soccer in Brazil performs a specified cluster of functions intensively and at national scale, which is a claim that can fail on the evidence for other activities and other countries. Second, breadth is an asset for comparison. A functional definition permits the inquiry to ask which institutions carry religious functions in a given society without first deciding which of them "really" count, which is the question a substantive definition forecloses.

The Category of Religion Is Itself Suspect

The fifth objection comes from the critique of the category itself. Talal Asad argues that "there cannot be a universal definition of religion, not only because its constituent elements and relationships are historically specific, but because that definition is itself the historical product of

discursive processes" (Asad, 1993, p. 29). On this view, applying a Durkheimian or Geertzian definition to Brazilian soccer imposes a historically particular, Western category on a phenomenon it does not fit.

Jonathan Z. Smith supplies the answer: "Religion is not a native term; it is a term created by scholars for their intellectual purposes and therefore is theirs to define" (Smith, 1998, p. 281). A scholarly definition is judged by the work it does within the inquiry, not by whether it captures the essence of the thing named. Furthermore, abandoning the category would not dispose of the comparative question of why a game commands the commitments it does in Brazil; it would merely leave that question unanswered. The functional definition is offered as an instrument and is justified by what it explains.

Brazil Is Indistinguishable from the West

The sixth objection inverts this paper's argument. If soccer's religious functions in Brazil match those identified by Bromberger in Europe and by Bain-Selbo and Price in the United States, then nothing about the Brazilian case is distinctive. The premise is correct, but the conclusion does not follow. Durkheim's theory predicts that sacralization, ritual assembly, collective effervescence, and the symbolic representation of the group will appear wherever collective life produces them, because it locates the origin of the sacred in the general dynamics of social life rather than in any particular culture.

What distinguishes Brazil is the content of the symbol system and the scale of its reach, which is the dimension Geertz's definition captures. In the United States, "sport" is part of a broader American civil religion whose central symbols remain constitutional and political (Bellah, 1967). In Argentina, Eduardo Archetti showed that football shares the work of national imagination with polo and the tango (Archetti, 1999). In Brazil, by contrast, the literature reviewed in the Background

section indicates that soccer is the single most important idiom in which the nation dramatizes, debates, and celebrates itself. That is the sense in which it is a national religion. Moreover, the game arrived as the import of a European-educated elite and was remade, in contested and often exclusionary ways, into a symbol of a mixed-race nation. Brazilian soccer thus illustrates both the reach of a European cultural form and the capacity of a postcolonial society to resignify it.

Commercialization Has Dissolved the Moral Community

The seventh objection is that the moral community this article describes no longer gathers in the stadium. The renovations for the 2014 World Cup turned Brazil's great public stadiums into arenas on a European model, part of the global commercialization of the game (Giulianotti, 1999). The Maracanã's *geral*, the standing area around the pitch where some thirty thousand spectators watched exposed to sun and rain, closed in 2005 (Ferreira, 2018, p. 4; Hollanda & Medeiros, 2014, pp. 337–338). The stadium reopened in 2013 at half its former size, as a heavily segmented arena designed for the consumer-fan (Ferreira, 2018, p. 5; Hollanda & Medeiros, 2014, p. 342). Rising ticket prices excluded the popular classes by indirect means, and individual seats in pre-assigned sectors atomized a crowd that had once stood together (Hollanda & Medeiros, 2014, pp. 344, 352; Paes Lopes & Hollanda, 2018, p. 214). If the stadium is the temple and the crowd the congregation, a temple that admits only those who can pay seems a poor vehicle for a moral community that unites the nation.

The objection identifies a real change, but it narrows the thesis rather than defeating it. First, the egalitarian stadium was always in part a representation. Hollanda and Medeiros describe the old Maracanã as commonly regarded as democratic and only *supposedly* cross-class (Hollanda & Medeiros, 2014, p. 338). In that respect it resembled the racial democracy narrative of Mário Filho and Freyre, which, as the Background section showed, simplified a history of exclusion. The

arenas were defended, in turn, as a way to include groups the old stadium had kept out, even as they excluded others (Ferreira, 2018, p. 5). Fernando Ferreira states the shift precisely: the filter of exclusion moved from the sociocultural to the socioeconomic (Ferreira, 2018, p. 5). The elite clubs of the 1920s excluded Black and working-class players by rule; the arena excludes working-class fans by price. In both periods the functional claim concerns the symbol of an inclusive nation, and that symbol has always outrun the practice.

Second, the reaction to the arenas is itself evidence of sacralization. Durkheim's sacred is what is set apart and protected against profanation. Organized supporters in São Paulo have mobilized against what they call "modern football," on the ground that the elitization of the stadiums corrupts the traditional culture of support (Paes Lopes & Hollanda, 2018, pp. 208–209). A community that defends its rites against commerce has not dissolved. What commercialization strains is the stadium as the place where the whole nation assembles, and how far the arena has displaced its working-class congregation is among the questions of class that the Conclusion leaves to fieldwork.

Conclusion

Soccer functions as a religion in Brazil, and that conclusion holds under a single, consistently applied functional framework. Under Durkheim's definition, soccer sets apart sacred places, times, persons, and objects and gathers Brazilians into ritual assemblies that produce collective effervescence and moral community. Under Geertz's definition, its symbols formulate a compelling conception of Brazil and clothe it with an aura of factuality. The evidence ordinarily read in substantive terms (superstition, relics, and the deification of players) is properly understood as ordinary religious function: ritual that regulates uncertainty, emblems that represent the group to itself, and persons who condense a collective self-image. Neither the breadth of the functional definition nor the critique of the category defeats the claim, and the generality of soccer's religious functions con-

firms rather than undermines it. The commercialization of the stadium narrows where that moral community gathers, but it has not dissolved it.

The analysis rests on published scholarship rather than original fieldwork, and its comparative claims call for systematic evidence. Three questions follow directly: how sporting rituals adapt when their apparent efficacy is disconfirmed; how soccer's religious functions are distributed across class, race, gender, and region within Brazil; and how the growth of evangelical Christianity is reshaping the game's sacred idiom. Each requires ethnographic work in Brazil. More broadly, the study of sport as religion has much to gain from looking beyond North America and Europe, and Brazil is the obvious place to begin.

References

Abrahão, B. O. D. L., Paoli, P. B., & Soares, A. J. (2011). Identidades ”raciais” e identidades nacionais: As representações do corpo negro na construção do ”estilo brasileiro de jogar futebol”. *Movimento (ESEFID/UFRGS)*, *17*(2), 195–210. https://doi.org/10.22456/1982-8918.19345

Archetti, E. P. (1999). *Masculinities: Football, polo and the tango in Argentina*. Berg.

Asad, T. (1993). The construction of religion as an anthropological category. In *Genealogies of religion: Discipline and reasons of power in Christianity and Islam* (pp. 27–54). Johns Hopkins University Press.

Bain-Selbo, E. (2009). *Game day and God: Football, faith, and politics in the American South*. Mercer University Press.

Bar-On, T. (2014). *The world through soccer: The cultural impact of a global sport*. Rowman & Littlefield.

Bastide, R. (1978). *The African religions of Brazil: Toward a sociology of the interpenetration of civilizations*. Johns Hopkins University Press.

Bellah, R. N. (1967). Civil religion in America. *Daedalus*, *96*(1), 1–21.

Berger, P. L. (1967). *The sacred canopy: Elements of a sociological theory of religion*. Doubleday.

Berger, P. L. (1974). Some second thoughts on substantive versus functional definitions of religion. *Journal for the Scientific Study of Religion*, *13*(2), 125–133.

Bocketti, G. (2016). *The invention of the beautiful game: Football and the making of modern Brazil*. University Press of Florida.

Bromberger, C. (1995). *Le match de football: Ethnologie d'une passion partisane à Marseille,*

Naples et Turin. Éditions de la Maison des sciences de l'homme.

Bruneau, T. C. (1982). *The church in Brazil: The politics of religion*. University of Texas Press.

Calin-Jageman, R. J., & Caldwell, T. L. (2014). Replication of the superstition and performance study by Damisch, Stoberock, and Mussweiler (2010). *Social Psychology*, *45*(3), 239–245. https://doi.org/10.1027/1864-9335/a000190

Chesnut, R. A. (1997). *Born again in Brazil: The Pentecostal boom and the pathogens of poverty*. Rutgers University Press.

Collins, R. (2004). *Interaction ritual chains*. Princeton University Press.

DaMatta, R. (1991). *Carnivals, rogues, and heroes: An interpretation of the Brazilian dilemma*. University of Notre Dame Press.

DaMatta, R. (Ed.). (1982). *Universo do futebol: Esporte e sociedade brasileira*. Pinakotheke.

Damisch, L., Stoberock, B., & Mussweiler, T. (2010). Keep your fingers crossed! How superstition improves performance. *Psychological Science*, *21*(7), 1014–1020. https://doi.org/10.1177/0956797610372631

Della Cava, R. (1976). Catholicism and society in twentieth-century Brazil. *Latin American Research Review*, *11*(2), 7–50. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0023879100030120

Durkheim, É. (1915). *The elementary forms of the religious life*. George Allen & Unwin.

Ferreira, F. D. C. (2018). Que estádio é esse? Em busca de uma taxonomia torcedora para o novo Maracanã. *Esporte e Sociedade*, *13*(31), 1–31. https://periodicos.uff.br/esportesociedade/article/download/49440/28718/169128

Franco Júnior, H. (2007). *A dança dos deuses: Futebol, sociedade, cultura*. Companhia das Letras.

Gaffney, C. T. (2008). *Temples of the earthbound gods: Stadiums in the cultural landscapes of Rio de Janeiro and Buenos Aires*. University of Texas Press.

Gastaldo, É. (2010). As relações jocosas futebolísticas: Futebol, sociabilidade e conflito no Brasil. *Mana*, *16*(2), 311–325. https://doi.org/10.1590/S0104-93132010000200003

Gastaldo, É. (2013). O fato social total brasileiro: Uma perspectiva etnográfica sobre a recepção pública da Copa do Mundo no Brasil. *Horizontes Antropológicos*, *19*(40), 185–200. https://doi.org/10.1590/S0104-71832013000200007

Geertz, C. (1973). Religion as a cultural system. In *The interpretation of cultures: Selected essays* (pp. 87–125). Basic Books.

Giulianotti, R. (1999). *Football: A sociology of the global game*. Polity Press.

Gmelch, G. (1971). Baseball magic. *Trans-action*, *8*(8), 39–41. https://doi.org/10.1007/BF02908325

Hoffman, S. J. (Ed.). (1992). *Sport and religion*. Human Kinetics.

Hollanda, B. B. B. D., & Medeiros, J. (2014). Do ”Colosso do Derby” à ”Arena Maracanã”: A cidade, o estádio e as percepções dos torcedores organizados de futebol sobre a Copa do Mundo de 2014. *Interseções: Revista de Estudos Interdisciplinares*, *16*(2), 328–353. https://doi.org/10.12957/irei.2014.16594

Instituto Brasileiro de Geografia e Estatística. (2025). *Censo Demográfico 2022: Religiões*.

Kittleson, R. (2014). *The country of football: Soccer and the making of modern Brazil*. University of California Press.

Leite Lopes, J. S. (2000). Class, ethnicity, and color in the making of Brazilian football. *Daedalus*, *129*(2), 239–270.

Lever, J. (1983). *Soccer madness*. University of Chicago Press.

Lise, N. S., Lise, R. S., de Freitas Júnior, M. A., & Capraro, A. M. (2017). Viajando em torno de Pelé: Construções literárias do ”rei” – Biografia, autobiografia e roteiro cinematográfico.

Movimento, *23*(1), 363–378. https://doi.org/10.22456/1982-8918.63088

Lofton, K. (2011). *Oprah: The gospel of an icon*. University of California Press.

Luckmann, T. (1967). *The invisible religion: The problem of religion in modern society*. Macmillan.

Mainwaring, S. (1986). *The Catholic Church and politics in Brazil, 1916–1985*. Stanford University Press.

Malinowski, B. (1948). *Magic, science and religion and other essays*. Free Press.

Mariano, R. (2004). Expansão pentecostal no Brasil: O caso da Igreja Universal. *Estudos Avançados*, *18*(52), 121–138. https://revistas.usp.br/eav/article/view/10028

Mariano, R. (2011). Laicidade à brasileira: Católicos, pentecostais e laicos em disputa na esfera pública. *Civitas: Revista de Ciências Sociais*, *11*(2), 238–258. https://www.redalyc.org/pdf/742/74220016005.pdf

Moraes, H. J. P., Damazio, L. P., & Bressan, L. L. (2018). Entre o profano e o sagrado: Ritos, símbolos e mitos na campanha de um time de futebol brasileiro. *Estudos em Comunicação*, *1*(27), 25–38. https://doi.org/10.20287/ec.n27.v1.a02

Mostaro, F. F. R., Helal, R. G., & Amaro, F. (2015). Futebol, nação e representações: A importância do estilo ”futebol-arte” na construção da identidade nacional. *História Unisinos*, *19*(3), 272–282. https://doi.org/10.4013/htu.2015.193.01

Murad, M. (2014). Soccer and society in Brazil. In W. Hofmeister & M. Sarmah (Eds.), *More than a game: Sports, society and politics* (pp. 99–103). Konrad-Adenauer-Stiftung.

Mário Filho. (1947). *O negro no futebol brasileiro*. Irmãos Pongetti.

Newson, M., Bortolini, T., Buhrmester, M., da Silva, S. R., de Aquino, J. N. Q., & Whitehouse, H. (2018). Brazil's football warriors: Social bonding and inter-group violence. *Evolution and*

Human Behavior, *39*(6), 675–683. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2018.06.010

Novak, M. (1976). *The joy of sports: End zones, bases, baskets, balls, and the consecration of the American spirit*. Basic Books.

Nunes, F. J. (2006). Futebol, religião e política entram em campo. *Revista do Núcleo de Estudos de Religião e Sociedade (NURES)*. https://revistas.pucsp.br/index.php/nures/article/view/7331

Paes Lopes, F. T., & Hollanda, B. B. B. D. (2018). ”Ódio eterno ao futebol moderno”: Poder, dominação e resistência nas arquibancadas dos estádios da cidade de São Paulo. *Tempo*, *24*(2), 206–232. https://doi.org/10.1590/TEM-1980-542X2018v240202

Pereira, L. A. D. M. (2000). *Footballmania: Uma história social do futebol no Rio de Janeiro, 1902–1938*. Nova Fronteira.

Petrognani, C. (2015). Avanço neopentecostal no futebol brasileiro: Análise sócio-antropológica acerca das relações entre religião, futebol e espaço público no Brasil. *El Futuro del Pasado*, *6*, 175–191. https://doi.org/10.14516/fdp.2015.006.001.007

Pierucci, A. F. (2004). ”Bye bye, Brasil”: O declínio das religiões tradicionais no Censo 2000. *Estudos Avançados*, *18*(52), 17–28. https://revistas.usp.br/eav/article/view/10021

Portal de Prefeitura. (2026, June 21). Pastor da IEADPE fala em ”idolatria do futebol” e compara Copa à fé cristã. *Portal de Prefeitura*. https://portaldeprefeitura.com.br/religiao/pastor-da-ieadpe-fala-em-idolatria-do-futebol-e-compara-copa-a/624946/

Prebish, C. S. (Ed.). (1993). *Religion and sport: The meeting of sacred and profane*. Greenwood Press.

Price, J. L. (Ed.). (2001). *From season to season: Sports as American religion*. Mercer University Press.

Rial, C. (2012). Banal religiosity: Brazilian athletes as new missionaries of the neo-Pentecostal diaspora. *Vibrant: Virtual Brazilian Anthropology*, *9*(2), 128–158. https://www.scielo.br/j/vb/a/yMdXJXb67vWWPPtk3MJQ5jG/

Risen, J. L. (2016). Believing what we do not believe: Acquiescence to superstitious beliefs and other powerful intuitions. *Psychological Review*, *123*(2), 182–207.

Schilbrack, K. (2013). What isn't religion? *Journal of Religion*, *93*(3), 291–318. https://doi.org/10.1086/670276

Schippers, M. C., & Van Lange, P. A. M. (2006). The psychological benefits of superstitious rituals in top sport: A study among top sportspersons. *Journal of Applied Social Psychology*, *36*(10), 2532–2553. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.0021-9029.2006.00116.x

Scholes, J., & Sassower, R. (2014). *Religion and sports in American culture*. Routledge.

Smith, J. Z. (1998). Religion, religions, religious. In M. C. Taylor (Ed.), *Critical terms for religious studies* (pp. 269–284). University of Chicago Press.

Souza, J. (2018). A linhagem culturalista da sociologia do futebol brasileiro. *Lua Nova*, 103–134. https://doi.org/10.1590/0102-103134/103

Spiro, M. E. (1966). Religion: Problems of definition and explanation. In M. Banton (Ed.), *Anthropological approaches to the study of religion* (pp. 85–126). Tavistock.

Vargas-Salfate, S., Páez, D., Oriol, X., da Costa, S., Gondim, S., & Techio, E. (2020). Nationalistic collective rituals, intergroup relations, and legitimation of national social systems. *International Review of Social Psychology*, *33*(1), 1–11. https://doi.org/10.5334/irsp.291

Vyse, S. A. (2014). *Believing in magic: The psychology of superstition* (Updated ed. ed.). Oxford University Press.

Xygalatas, D., da Silva Profeta, V. L., Saraei, M., & Baranowski-Pinto, G. (2025). Route of fire:

Pregame rituals and emotional synchrony among Brazilian football fans. *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, *122*(24). https://doi.org/10.1073/pnas.2422779122